

Your Wedding Day

Photography Timeline.

The timeline is the photography.

How to protect the windows that produce the images you'll keep forever.

- Why the timeline determines everything.
- The six photography windows — every wedding has them.
- Getting ready — how much time and why.
- Ceremony types — Catholic, civil, outdoor, intimate.
- Family formals — the strategy that saves an hour.
- Couple portraits & golden hour — protecting what matters.
- Reception — the key moments and how to flag them.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

"Genuine. Intentional. Timeless."

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WELCOME

The Timeline Is *the Photography.*

Not the venue. Not the light. Not the photographer.

What is possible on your wedding day is determined by your timeline.

*“A great photographer with a broken timeline produces average images.
A protected timeline with intention produces images that last a lifetime.”*

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

No two weddings are the same. A Catholic high Mass at Saint William with 300 guests runs on a completely different clock than a 40-person garden ceremony at a Hill Country ranch. A timeline that works for one would collapse the other. This guide does not give you a sample schedule.

It gives you something more useful: the six photography windows that exist in every wedding — regardless of format, venue, or ceremony type — and the specific time allocations and decisions within each one that determine what we can actually capture on your day.

Share this with your wedding coordinator. The timeline is built together — between you, your coordinator, and us. All three need to understand the same priorities. This guide ensures that conversation happens before the day, not on it.

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01

The Six Photography Windows.

Every wedding — regardless of format, venue, size, or ceremony type — contains these six photography windows. The order may shift. The duration varies. But all six exist, and all six require intentional time allocation.

WINDOW 1

Getting Ready

60–90 min photography coverage

Two photographers work simultaneously — one with each partner. The morning, the details, the last moments before everything changes. Cannot be recreated.

WINDOW 2

Pre-Ceremony Portraits

20–40 min (if first look)

The first look and couple portraits before the ceremony. Optional but powerful — protects the portrait window post-ceremony and produces the most intimate images of the day.

WINDOW 3

Ceremony

Varies by ceremony type

Coverage depends on your ceremony format, venue restrictions, and length. Catholic Mass: 60–90 min. Civil outdoor: 20–40 min. We cover every format.

WINDOW 4

Family Formals

20–30 min

Immediately after the ceremony. Immediate family, grandparents, key groupings. List prepared in advance. Coordinator manages groupings. We direct the composition.

WINDOW 5

Couple Portraits

30–45 min

The most important photography window. Most commonly compressed by timeline pressure. Protected time = the images you will display for the rest of your lives.

WINDOW 6

Reception

2–5 hours

Grand entrance, first dance, parent dances, toasts, cake cutting, open dancing. Key moments flagged in advance. Two photographers for simultaneous coverage.

TWO PHOTOGRAPHERS — ALWAYS

Windows 1 and 6 run simultaneously with two photographers. Getting ready: one with the bride, one with the groom, same start time. Reception: simultaneous coverage of dance floor, guest reactions, and couple moments.

02

Getting Ready.

The first photography window. Two photographers arrive simultaneously — one with each partner — so nothing from either morning is missed.

HOW MUCH TIME

- + **Photography arrival: 60–90 min before departure.**
We arrive 60–90 minutes before you need to leave for the ceremony. Not from the start of hair and makeup — from the final window: last chair time, dressing, bridal party portraits. This is when the images that matter are made.
- + **30-minute buffer is non-negotiable.**
Hair runs long. Someone is late. A button breaks. The buffer absorbs all of it without compressing what comes after. Without it, delays from getting ready cascade through every window that follows.
- + **Bride dresses near the end.**
The dressing sequence is one of the most photographed moments of the morning. It should happen when there is still time, not when the car is waiting. Build 20–30 minutes of protected dressing time immediately before departure.
- + **Two locations simultaneously.**
Because we work as two photographers, bride and groom getting ready coverage happens at the same time, not sequentially. Both partners receive full morning coverage without any compromise to either timeline.

WHAT WE COVER

- + **Detail flat lays.**
Rings, shoes, invitation, jewelry, florals, veil. Photographed early while the room is still calm. Have everything on one clean surface when we arrive.
- + **The candid morning.**
The energy between you and your closest people, the quiet moments, the laughter. We move through the room without disrupting the morning.
- + **The dressing sequence.**
The gown going on, the lacing or buttoning, the first look in the mirror. This requires direction and space. We position for every moment of it.
- + **Bridal and bridal party portraits.**
Quick portrait passes before departure. Individual and group. These happen in the final window — after dressing, before leaving.
- + **Groom and groomsmen.**
Suit details, boutonniere, cufflinks, candid moments. Our second photographer handles this in full while the first is with the bride.

03

Ceremony Types.

Every ceremony format requires different coverage, different positioning, and different time expectations. Here is what changes — and what we need to know in advance.

Catholic Mass

60–90 min

The most complex ceremony format photographically. Many Catholic churches have strict photography restrictions: no flash, designated positions only, no movement during key moments (consecration, communion). We work within every restriction — but we need the rules in writing at least two weeks before. Surprise restrictions on the day affect what we can capture. The processional, vows, ring exchange, and recessional are always covered fully. Light in churches varies widely — from beautiful directional window light to challenging fluorescent overhead. We shoot clean in both.

Civil / Non-Religious Ceremony

20–45 min

The most flexible format. No institutional restrictions. We can position freely, use flash when appropriate, and move throughout. Shorter length means every moment is more concentrated — the processional, the vows, the ring exchange, and the first kiss happen quickly and require full attention from both photographers simultaneously. Venue light direction matters here: for outdoor ceremonies, the couple should face away from harsh direct sun. We discuss positioning with your coordinator before the ceremony begins.

Outdoor Venue Ceremony

20–60 min

Weather and light are the primary variables. Overcast is not a problem — it is a large soft box. Harsh midday sun requires coordinated positioning. Golden hour ceremonies (beginning 60–90 min before sunset) produce the most cinematic ceremony light of any format. If your ceremony time is within two hours of sunset, tell us — we plan the positioning specifically around it. Rain protocols are discussed before the wedding. We shoot in any weather.

Intimate Ceremony / Elopement

10–30 min

Small ceremonies move fast and feel completely different from large weddings. Fewer guests means more access, more flexibility, and more creative freedom. We can get closer, try more, and spend more time on portraits than any other format allows. The entire day becomes portrait-forward. If you're planning an elopement or micro-wedding, talk to us before building the timeline — the entire structure of the day is different and works in your favor photographically.

Destination / Multi-Day Wedding

Full weekend

Destination weddings require coordination across multiple days, locations, and often travel. We discuss the full weekend schedule before anything is confirmed. Rehearsal dinner coverage, day-after sessions, and location scouting are built into the Wedding Story Collection for this reason. If you're planning a destination wedding, reach out early — travel and accommodation logistics are handled at the time of booking.

CEREMONY RULE — Tell us your format, your venue, and any restrictions at least two weeks before.

04

Family Formals & The First Look.

Two decisions that have the most impact on your timeline — and therefore on the couple portrait time that follows.

FAMILY FORMALS

- + **Budget 2–3 minutes per grouping.**
A family formals list of 10 groupings takes 20–30 minutes under good conditions. Every grouping beyond 10 adds 2–3 minutes. A 20-grouping list costs 45–60 minutes. That time comes directly from couple portraits.
- + **8–10 groupings is the target.**
Immediate family, grandparents, and siblings. Everything else can often be captured at the reception when guests are gathered naturally. Keep the formal list to what cannot happen any other way.
- + **Send the list in advance.**
Share your family formals list at least one week before the wedding. Named groupings, in order of priority. A prepared list moves twice as fast as an improvised one on the day.
- + **Brief your family before the ceremony.**
Tell immediate family before the ceremony begins: stay near the altar after the recessional. Do not go to cocktail hour. Every person who disappears costs five minutes of searching.
- + **Designate a family coordinator.**
One person — your coordinator, a bridesmaid, or a trusted family member — calls the groupings. We direct the composition. Trying to do both simultaneously costs everyone time.

THE FIRST LOOK

- + **What it is.**
A private, planned moment where you see each other before the ceremony — just the two of you and us. Usually 30–60 minutes before the ceremony begins, at a quiet corner of your venue.
- + **What it gives you photographically.**
Genuine, private emotion. Couple portraits before the ceremony when you're fresh, unhurried, and present. The most intimate images of the day almost always come from first looks.
- + **What it gives your timeline.**
Moving couple portraits before the ceremony removes them from the post-ceremony crunch. After the ceremony you are managing guests, family formals, and reception pressure. Before it, you have protected time.
- + **If you prefer not to.**
Some couples want the ceremony moment to be the first time. That is completely valid. If you skip the first look, protect at minimum 30–40 minutes for couple portraits immediately after family formals end. Not after you've greeted a few guests. Immediately.
- + **For Catholic weddings specifically.**
A first look before a Catholic Mass is especially valuable because the Mass itself often limits photography access and runs 60–90 minutes. Having couple portraits complete before the ceremony removes all timeline pressure from the most complex part of the day.

05

Couple Portraits & Golden Hour.

Window 5 is the one that gets compressed most often on wedding days. It is also the window that produces the images you will look at the most. It requires active protection.

COUPLE PORTRAITS

- + **Minimum 20 minutes. Ideal: 45.**
20 minutes is enough to produce strong portraits if the window is protected and both partners are present. 45 minutes allows for multiple locations, a full warm-up, and the kind of variety that fills an album. The difference between 20 and 45 minutes shows in every gallery.
- + **Exit immediately after family formals.**
Not after you greet a few guests. Not after one more family photo. Immediately. Every minute spent in transition is a minute taken from the one window that cannot be recovered.
- + **Both of you mentally present.**
Portrait sessions where one partner is thinking about the reception produce portraits that reflect exactly that. Make the decision before you leave the ceremony: the next 30 minutes belong to the two of you.
- + **Location scouted in advance.**
We scout your venue before the day. You will not spend portrait time searching for a backdrop. You walk where you are directed.

GOLDEN HOUR

- + **What it is.**
The 60–90 minutes before sunset. Warm, directional, low light that is uniquely flattering to white fabric, skin tones, and natural environments. The light that produces the most cinematic wedding portraits.
- + **Why it matters in Austin.**
Austin's fall and spring golden hour is extraordinary. October at 6:30 PM looks different from any other light in the year. If your reception window overlaps with sunset, a 20-minute portrait exit before introductions captures something the rest of the day cannot.
- + **How to plan for it.**
Know your sunset time on your wedding date. Build a 20–30 minute couple portrait window between family formals and reception introductions. Guests will be fine at cocktail hour. Tell your coordinator this matters.
- + **Overcast days.**
Overcast is not a problem. An overcast sky is a large, even soft box — no harsh shadows, no squinting, no competing light sources. Do not reschedule or cancel a portrait window because of clouds.
- + **Rain.**
Rain with a covered location can produce some of the most dramatic wedding portraits of any condition. If it rains, call us. Do not make decisions about the portrait window without talking to us first.

06

Reception Coverage.

The reception is covered by two photographers working simultaneously. One on the couple and key moments. One on guests, reactions, and the room. Here is how to make sure nothing is missed.

KEY MOMENTS TO FLAG

- + **Grand introduction.**
Walk in deliberately. Not a sprint. We position in advance. This is one of the most joyful frames of the reception and it lasts about 15 seconds.
- + **First dance.**
Coordinate with your DJ and lighting designer: we need at least moderate ambient light during the first dance. Full blackout with a single spotlight produces one-dimensional images. Communicate this before the day.
- + **Parent dances.**
Same lighting note. These happen once. Brief the DJ in advance, not when the song starts.
- + **Toasts.**
Brief your speakers: hold the glass up at the end. The toast-and-clink moment with your reaction is the image from every toast. Most speakers forget without a prompt.
- + **Cake cutting.**
Not on a fixed schedule. Give us a 5-minute heads-up before it happens. Your coordinator can do this. We should be in position before it starts, not running toward it.

HOW TO COMMUNICATE WITH US

- + **Share the final vendor timeline 1 week before.**
Confirmed times, locations, and sequences. Not a draft. The final version. We plan our entire coverage around it.
- + **Flag anything that might change.**
A ceremony that tends to run long. A family member who may be late. A surprise moment planned for the reception. Anything that affects timing — tell us in advance.
- + **Your coordinator is our primary contact.**
On the day, we work directly with your coordinator. You should not be managing logistics on your wedding day. Brief your coordinator on any photography priorities before the day begins.
- + **Coverage end time.**
Our coverage ends at the time specified in your contract. If you want coverage to extend, discuss this in advance. Extensions are available and arranged before the day.
- + **After the reception.**
Sneak peek within 48 hours. Full edited gallery within 4–6 weeks. Album selections are made from your gallery once you've had time to look.

“Share this guide with your coordinator before the day. The timeline is built together.”

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About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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